

2026

Grade 8 FINAL EXAM

READINGS BOOKLET

The **Grade 8 English Language Arts Final Exam** has 2 BOOKLETS:

The READINGS BOOKLET contains 11 reading selections.

The QUESTIONS BOOKLET has 75 questions.

You need them both!

You may NOT use a dictionary, thesaurus, or other reference materials.

I. Read the short story “The Strange Orchid” by H. G. Wells and answer questions 1 - 15 from your Questions Booklet.

The Strange Orchid by H. G. Wells

1 Arthur Wedderburn was a shy, lonely man. There was very little that was interesting in his life. He had inherited just enough money to live off. He didn't have a job, or a wife, or children. He might have spent his time collecting coins or writing poetry. As it happened, he grew orchids.

5 He had his own greenhouse, and he often went to orchid sales. There was a certain thrill in buying orchids. You could buy a brown dried-up root, not knowing exactly what kind of orchid it would produce. If you were very lucky, it might be a spectacular new kind of flower.

 One morning, Wedderburn was eating breakfast with his housekeeper. He told her, “I have a feeling that something is going to happen to me today.”

10 “Oh, don't say *that!*” she said. She always thought that “something happening” meant trouble.

 “I don't mean that anything bad will happen,” he said. “It's just that there's an orchid sale in London today. They're selling some plants that a fellow named Batten found in the East Indies.”

15 “Is that the same Batten you told me about the other day?” she asked. “Is that the one who died?”

 “Yes.” Wedderburn said. “I wonder why nothing exciting ever happens to me. Things happen to other people. Take Batten, for instance. He was only 36 when he died. But he'd already been married twice. He almost died of malaria four times. Once he killed an elephant.

20 Once he was shot with a poisoned dart. In the end he was killed by jungle leeches.”

 “I'd rather not have so much excitement,” said the housekeeper. “If you're going to London, you'd better take an umbrella. It might rain.”

 When Wedderburn returned that evening, he was excited. He had bought several orchid roots which he showed the housekeeper.

25 He touched one of the roots and said, “This one was not identified. It may be a new kind of orchid. It was the last one that Batten ever collected.”

 “I don't like the look of it,” said the housekeeper. “It looks like a spider playing dead.”

 Wedderburn smiled. “It's hard to judge orchids by their roots. It may turn out to be a very beautiful flower. I'll plant it tomorrow.”

30 He paused, then added, “they found poor Batten lying dead in a swamp. One of these

Continued...

orchids was crushed under his body. He had had some kind of fever, and I guess he must have fainted. When they found him every drop of blood had been drained out of him by jungle leeches. It may have cost him his life to find this plant!”

The housekeeper shuddered. “How awful to die in a nasty swamp.”

35 “He died doing what he wanted to do,” Wedderburn said. “And it does make this plant especially interesting.”

The next few days were busy for Wedderburn. He spent hours in his greenhouse.

The strange orchid – the one found under Batten – began to show signs of life.

Wedderburn was delighted. He took the housekeeper out to the greenhouse and showed it to her.

40 “That is a bud,” he pointed out. “Soon there will be leaves over here. And those little things are roots that grow above the soil. Like the roots below, they take in both air and moisture.”

“They look like little white fingers reaching out,” she said. “I don’t like them.”

“I have never seen an orchid quite like this,” he said. “Perhaps it will make me famous.”

45 After one more visit, the housekeeper refused to go into the greenhouse anymore. By then, the outside roots had grown about a foot long. They reminded her of long arms reaching after something, and she had nightmares about them. So Wedderburn had to admire the plant by himself.

The orchid was beginning to grow leaves now. They were broad, shiny, and dark green.

50 Near the stems there were little dots of dark red. Wedderburn had never seen leaves like that before.

Every day, he went to see if a flower had bloomed. And at last, the great day arrived.

When he entered the greenhouse, there was a rich, sweet smell in the air.

55 Wedderburn hurried over to the strange orchid. It now held three great blossoms. They were white, with streaks of gold along the edges. The centers were purple mixed with gold. He knew at once that this was a new kind of orchid.

Wedderburn was delighted, but he felt strange. The smell was so sweet, and the greenhouse was so hot!

60 He would see if the temperature was right. He took a step – and the brick floor seemed to move up and down. Then the whole greenhouse seemed to swing up sideways, as he fainted.

At 4:30, the housekeeper had tea ready. But Wedderburn did not show up.

“He must be studying that horrible orchid,” she told herself.

Continued...

She went to the greenhouse, opened the door, and called his name. There was no reply. She noticed that the air was very stuffy and smelled very sweet. Then she saw Wedderburn lying on the brick floor, and she froze.

She did not understand. Then she saw a drop of blood trickle down his cheek from beneath one of the roots.

The smell of the blossoms began to make her dizzy. She knew she must not faint. So she ran outside and breathed in cool, fresh air. Then she took a flower pot and smashed the windows at the end of the greenhouse.

With garden shears, she cut through the sucker roots one by one. Finally, Wedderburn was free, but he was very pale, and he was bleeding from a dozen spots.

Wedderburn opened his eyes and asked, "What's the matter?"

“What about my orchid?” he asked weakly.

Wedderburn had lost a great deal of blood. Otherwise, he was all right. The doctor told him to stay in bed for a few days.

Cold air blew in through the broken windows. The sweet smell was almost gone. Some of the torn roots lay withered upon the floor. The doctor bent to look closer. One of the roots stirred a little, and the doctor stepped quickly away.

(End)

II. Read the poem “LOST” by Carl Sandburg, and answer questions 16 - 18 from your Questions Booklet.

LOST by Carl Sandburg

1 DESOLATE and lone
 All night long on the lake
 Where fog trails and mist creeps,
 The whistle of a boat
5 Calls and cries unendingly,
 Like some lost child
 In tears and trouble
 Hunting the harbor's breast
 And the harbor's eyes.

(End)

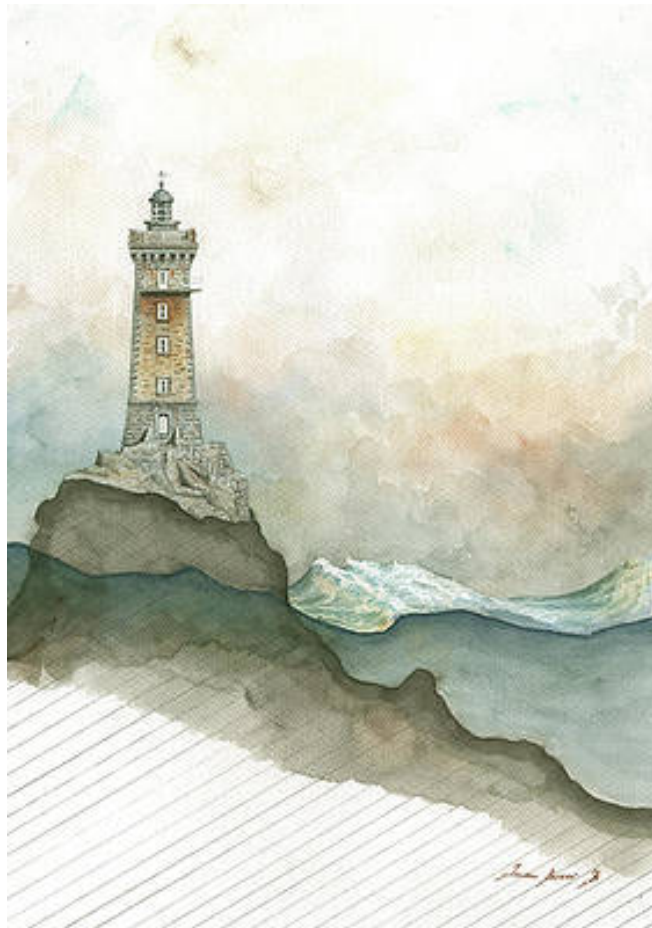


Image: <https://render.fineartamerica.com>

III. Read the letter “Missing Out on Joys of River Cruising” by Jan Thygesen, and answer questions 19 - 23 from your Questions Booklet.

Missing Out on Joys of River Cruising

This letter is written by Jan Thygesen, who is the Manager of Marathon Marine in Edmonton, Alberta, a custom jet boat builder.

1 Your article on river safety had many worthwhile tips. My concern is with a consistent tone over the past several years that the river and those who use it are dangerous. Most boaters on the river are responsible.

5 Rivers are marvelous places. Unlike a lake, every time you go around the bend it is like a new place. They are completely different depending upon the water level. In times of high water there are lots of little channels you can run and explore.

10 In late summer and fall on a sunny day, when the water is clear and you are cruising in six inches of water with rocks flashing underneath, it cannot be beaten. There are many places on the river where you would be hard pressed to realize you are in a city.

15 Unfortunately the perception in urban settings is that boating on rivers is dangerous. This is contrary to the facts. We know of only two people that have died in twenty five years while on jet boats. One was in a race and crashed into a bank, while the other was boating at night which is risky on a river or lake. Contrast this to the annual toll of people on our roads and lakes.

20 A jet boat is a **versatile** craft which can handle anything the North Saskatchewan throws at it. The technology has been developed over thirty years, much of it right here in Edmonton. A key issue not mentioned in the article is that some boats on the river do not have safety flotation built into them, as required by law. The flotation is there to keep the boat afloat in case it becomes flooded. It is the boat’s equivalent to your lifejacket.

(End)

IV. Read the short story “My Left Foot” by Christy Brown, and answer questions 24 - 30 from your Questions Booklet.

My Left Foot by Christy Brown

Christy Brown, who was born in Ireland in 1932, suffered from cerebral palsy, a disease that makes it difficult to control body movements and to speak clearly. In this excerpt from “My Left Foot,” he writes about discovering a way to communicate.

1 I was now ten and a half and beginning to sink deeper and deeper into myself. Mother tried, but nothing could rouse me, nothing could bring back the happy child that used to be me. He didn’t exist anymore. In his place was a tense, silent, great-eyed creature who had nerves as sharp as broken glass and as taut as telegraph wires.

5 Then, one Christmas, one of us—I think it was Paddy—got a box of paints from Santa Claus. That same year I got a box of toy soldiers, but the moment I saw Paddy’s paints with all the wonderful colours and the long, slender fuzzy-haired brush I fell in love with them at once. I felt I must have them to keep as my own. I was fascinated by the little solid blocks of paint—blue, red, yellow, green and white. Later in the day I sat and watched Paddy as he tried
10 to make some impression with the paints on a piece of white cardboard torn from an old shoe box, but he only made a mess and in a queer way I felt annoyed with him—and a bit jealous.

“Blow—I can’t use these things!” he grumbled, flinging his own brush down. “They’re only for girls.”

I saw my chance. Pushing out my box of lead soldiers towards him with my foot, I asked
15 him, in grunts, to “swop” them for his paints.

“Done!” exclaimed Paddy, glad to get rid of such a sissy’s toy. “But how are you going to use them?”

I didn’t know that myself, but I just lifted my left foot and smiled.

I put them away till all the excitement of Christmas was past. Then one quiet afternoon
20 when there was nobody in the kitchen but mother and myself I crawled over to the press¹, opened the door with my foot and took the little black box of paints out and laid it on the floor in front of me.

“What are you up to?” said mother, coming over to where I squatted with my back against the wall. “Surely you’re not trying to paint!”

25 I nodded very solemnly. I picked up the brush between my toes, wetted it in my mouth,

Continued...

¹ press – a large free-standing closet or cupboard with doors

then rubbed it on one of the paint squares—the bright blue one which I liked best. I next rubbed the brush against my other foot—and saw a blue spot on it when I took it away.

“It works!” I managed to exclaim, and could feel my face hot with excitement.

“I’ll get you water,” said mother, going into the pantry and coming back with a cupful
30 which she put on the floor beside me.

I had no paper. Mother got me some by tearing a page out of Peter’s sum-copy².

I dipped the brush into the water and rubbed on some vivid red paint. Then I steadied my foot and, while mother looked on intently, painted on the open page before me—the outline of a cross.

35 I grinned triumphantly up at her. I remembered how, on that day five years previously, we had sat together on the floor, almost in the same spot, while I shook and sweated as I drew with my left foot for the first time. Mother had been there at my side then—she was at my side now, still inspiring me onwards.

There was no sweating or shaking this time. I did it quite smoothly. I was holding a
40 painting brush now, not a broken piece of chalk. But it meant the same thing—I had discovered a new way to communicate with the outside world, a new way to talk with my left foot.

As time went on I became more and more devoted to my little box of paints. I painted all sorts of crazy things, from a sketch of Peter’s face—to which he indignantly objected—to a bunch of dead fish lying in the dustbin, done before Tibby the cat from next door finished them
45 off.

Then mother managed to buy me some more paints and brushes, along with one or two drawing books and a pencil. This of course, broadened my range of expression and allowed me to have a greater choice of subject. After the first few weeks of uncertainty and awkwardness, I settled down contentedly with my new pastime. I painted every day upstairs in the back
50 bedroom, completely by myself.

I was changing. I didn’t know it then, but I had found a way to be happy again and to forget some of the things that had made me unhappy. Above all I learned to forget myself. I didn’t miss going out with my brothers now, for I had something to keep my mind active, something to make each day, a thing to look forward to.

55 I would sit crouched on the floor for hours, holding the brush between my toes, my right leg curled up under my left, my arms held tightly at my sides, the hands clenched. All my paints and brushes were around me, and I would get mother or father to pin the drawing paper to the floor with tacks to keep it steady. It looked a very queer awkward position, with my head

Continued...

² sum-copy – a notebook for practicing arithmetic

almost between my knees and my back as crooked as a corkscrew. But I painted all my best
60 pictures in this way, with the wooden floor as my only easel.

Slowly I began to lose my early depression. I had a feeling of pure joy while I painted, a
feeling I had never experienced before and which seemed almost to lift me above myself. It
was only when I wasn't painting that I became depressed and cross with everyone at home. At
first mother thought she was doing the right thing in encouraging me to paint, thinking it would
65 give me less time to become unhappy.

But after a while she began to worry, because I was spending so much time alone. I'd sit
for hours painting in the bedroom upstairs, unconscious of everything—including myself.

She often came up the stairs to see if I wanted anything, coming on tip-toe into the room.
There she'd find me, bent over a picture, the brush in my toes.

70 Sometimes she'd come over to brush the hair out of my eyes and wipe the sweat from my
forehead, for although I could now use my left foot as easily as Peter or Paddy could use their
hands, it was still a terrific strain on the rest of my body to sit on the floor crouched over a
picture for almost the whole day. But often when mother came up to see if I was all right, I'd
74 just nod my head curtly and grunt.

(End)

Credit Statement:

My Left Foot, by Christy Brown. Published by Martin Secker & Warburg Ltd. Reprinted by permission of
Reed Consumer Books.

V. Read the poem by Lisa Sloman and answer questions 31 - 33 from your Questions Booklet.

Time

By Lisa Sloman

- 1 A generation ago
 they paraded.
 “Flower Power,”
 “Make love, not war.”
- 5 Out to change the world,
 To voice their thoughts,
 To be individuals.
- Now they’ve grown,
 and we are what they were once.
- 10 Out to change the world,
 To voice our thoughts
 To be our own individuals.
 “Shush,”
 We’re told
- 15 “You’re not old enough,
 You don’t know what you want.”
- Suddenly they’ve forgotten
 who they once were,
 what they once fought for.
- 20 What they thought,
 when they were told to.

(End)

VI. Read the article by Harry Baker and answer questions 34 - 42 from your Questions Booklet.

Unicorn-like Blind Fish Discovered in Dark Waters Deep in Chinese Cave
by Harry Baker

Researchers stumbled across a bizarre species of blind cave fish with a mysterious, horn-like structure protruding from its head and a lack of scales or pigmentation.



A living specimen of the new species, *Sinocyclocheilus longicornis*, in a laboratory tank. (Image credit: Xu et al. 2023)

1 Lurking within the dark waters of Chinese caves is a bizarre fish species that has an uncanny resemblance with mythical equine creatures. Researchers found in a new study that these fish weirdos were hiding in a pitch-black pool the size of a kitchen table. They have no scales or color, tiny rudimentary eyes (that likely cannot see anything) and an unusually large
5 horn jutting out of their foreheads.

The researchers found the drab, unicorn-like fish while surveying cave fish from the genus³ *Sinocyclocheilus*. Fish in this genus are found only in China, usually within small pools that are shrouded in darkness. There are 76 known species of *Sinocyclocheilus*, most of which share similar characteristics with the newfound species, such as reduced or no vision, a
10 lack of scales and no pigmentation. However, only some *Sinocyclocheilus* fish possess a horn, and others have lost their eyes completely in a process known as **regressive evolution**, in which species lose complex features over generations. There are also a handful of *Sinocyclocheilus* species that live in illuminated waters and lack the unusual features associated with their freaky cousins.

15 Researchers discovered the newfound fish swimming in a small pool measuring 5.9 feet (1.8 meters) wide and 2.6 feet (0.8 m) deep, inside a cave in the mountainous Guizhou province. The team collected individuals to take back to the lab and examine, unaware that they were collecting a never-before-seen species. After comparing the fish with other known species and analyzing their DNA, the researchers realized what they had uncovered.

³ Genus: A class, kind, or group marked by common characteristics or by one common characteristic

In the new study, published Jan. 17 in the journal ZooKeys, the team described the species, which they named *S. longicornus*. The fish are between 4.1 and 5.7 inches (10.5 to 14.6 centimeters) long and possess two pairs of whisker-like barbels that they use to feel their way around in the dark. But perhaps their most interesting feature is their unusually long horn-like structure, which has no clear use, and isn't found in closely related species. (The name *longicornus* is derived from the Latin words *longus*, meaning "long," and *cornu*, meaning "horn of the forehead.")

These horn-like structures differ widely among dark-dwelling *Sinocyclocheilus* species; they vary in length and can either be forked or non-forked, like in *S. longicornus*. As light-dwelling species do not have horns, these appendages likely have something to do with living in the dark, but it is not clear what their purpose is, the researchers wrote in the paper.

The most logical explanation would be that the horns help these fish to "see" in the dark, but their barbels already enable them to navigate around their pool, which is not very big so would likely require minimal navigation skills anyway. Most *Sinocyclocheilus* species, including *S. longicornus*, also have a fully formed lateral line — an organ made up of highly sensitive cells that runs laterally down a fish's body and detects changes in pressure, temperature and salinity — so the horn is also unlikely to be needed to detect those.

However, the unusual size of the horn on *S. longicornus*, coupled with the fact the new species is not closely related to other long-horned species, suggests that longhorns have emerged on at least two separate occasions in the genus, researchers wrote. Therefore, comparing the environmental conditions of *S. longicornus* with some of the other long-horned species could finally reveal what the mysterious structures are actually used for.

<https://www.livescience.com/new-species-horned-cave-fish-china>

Harry Baker

Staff Writer

Harry is a U.K.-based staff writer at Live Science. He studied Marine Biology at the University of Exeter (Penryn campus) and after graduating started his own blog site "Marine Madness," which he continues to run with other ocean enthusiasts. He is also interested in evolution, climate change, robots, space exploration, environmental conservation and anything that's been fossilized. When not at work he can be found watching sci-fi films, playing old Pokemon games or running (probably slower than he'd like).

VII. Read the short story “The King” and answer questions 43 - 53 from your Questions Booklet.

The King

1 One dismal morning in late November, the month when country people, as well as animals, are not quite themselves, Charlie, who had taken the King to bed with him, awakened to find himself most unwilling to get up. The prospect of a four mile bike ride to school in that cold, dreary, drizzling weather was repulsive, and he lingered as long as possible.

5 Then he had to hurry. He dived into his underwear and socks, slid the King into his cage and slammed the door, forgetting to lock it, grabbed the rest of his clothes and ran downstairs, leaving the door of his room half open. He finished dressing, gulped down some cocoa, and was off, not quite awake.

10 An hour later, Charlie’s mother, mooning about the kitchen in her bare feet as usual, decided that she was tired of washing dishes, and would much prefer to hang a water colour that she had finished and framed the day before. She started up to Charlie’s room to borrow his hammer, forgetting that the door was supposed to be locked, forgetting all those horrid crawling things in there, even forgetting that Charlie was at school.

15 Charlie’s room was directly under the roof, and went the whole length of the house. It had once been the storage room and still was, to some extent. It was also his workshop, playroom, bedroom, and finally, a collection room. His mother had gone a good way into it before she saw the King advancing towards her with speed and beaming good will which was by no means obvious to her. She stopped, paralyzed, and the King, always the perfect host, coiled into a graceful spiral and reared two feet of himself from the floor, flicking his black, 20 forked, eight-inch tongue rapidly, in a friendly attempt to find out who was there.

25 The poor lady could not remember later how she got out of that room or succeeded in closing the door and locking it. She made her way to the bathroom where she was sick. Then, after shutting herself in her bedroom, she went to bed under the covers with all her clothes on. This was how her husband found her late that afternoon when he came home from work. She 25 was calm and inclined to blame herself for being overcome by what, after all, was just one of God’s creatures. However, she was too weak to get up and make supper or, indeed, to do anything.

30 Charlie and I arrived soon after that, my having been invited to spend the night. We found Charlie’s father sitting on the porch in shirt sleeves, in that weather. He had beside him Charlie’s 22, a packet of cartridges, and a spade. He indicated these with a wave of his hand

Continued...

and went into the house without a word.

Charlie's face immediately lost all expression. He went quickly to his room, and came down with the King festooned over his left arm. He took the rifle and cartridges, I the spade, and together we went out past the tool shed, into the woods beyond.

35 Here Charlie stopped and deposited the King gently on a bed of moss. Then he loaded his rifle (a single shot) and fired it into the ground. He waited for a few seconds, re-loaded, and fired again.

40 He unbuttoned his jacket and shirt and picked up the King, who was beginning to show signs of annoyance at being awakened and taken out into the cold. (He sounded like a large kettle about to come to a boil.) Charlie inserted the King's head inside his shirt and the King, pleased at finding a warm place, instantly poured himself all the way in, wrapped himself several times around Charlie's small middle and went to sleep again.

45 We waited a while, then went back to the house. We went upstairs, supposedly to wash, and Charlie unwound the King, not without a little coaxing, and put him in the cage. Then we ate supper, which Charlie and I prepared, in complete silence. His mother did not appear, and his father apparently considered the business closed.

(End)

VIII. Read the poem “To Look At Any Thing” by John Moffitt and answer questions 54 - 56 from your Questions Booklet.

To Look At Any Thing
-John Moffitt

1 To look at any thing,
 If you would know that thing,
 You must look at it long:
 To look at this green and say,
5 "I have seen spring in these
 Woods," will not do - you must
 Be the thing you see:
 You must be the dark snakes of
 Stems and ferny plumes of leaves,
10 You must enter in
 To the small silences between
 The leaves,
 You must take your time
 And touch the very peace
15 They issue from.

(End)



Image: <https://i.pinimg.com/originals>

IX. Read the article “Earthquakes: Rock the World” by Barbara Saffer and answer questions 57-63.

Earthquakes: Rock the World

By BARBARA SAFFER

1 Section 1: _____

You may not be able to feel it, but the continent you live on is in constant motion. Scientists explain continental movement by the theory of *plate tectonics*. Plates are thick slabs, like pieces of a jigsaw puzzle, which make up the crust of the Earth. These plates float - like
5 rafts on the sea - on a layer of hot, mobile rock called the *mantle*. We don't usually notice the motion because plates move very slowly - about as fast as your fingernails grow.

On occasion, however, we are jolted into remembering. Where one plate slides beneath another, volcanoes spit out masses of fiery lava. Where plates collide, earthquakes rock the world! As residents of Turkey well know, (see photo) an earthquake is a sudden shaking of the
10 Earth's surface. Hundreds of thousands of earthquakes jiggle the planet every year. A major tremor, however, can cause enormous damage.

Section 2: How Earthquakes Happen

Earthquakes occur when the thick plates of the Earth's surface crack or break suddenly or
15 slide past one another. Most earthquakes occur near plate boundaries. This is where the slabs slide together, drift apart, or creep past each other. These motions are slow and cumbersome, and plates often get stuck as they try to scrape past each other.

If a plate is trying to move, but can't, the plate bends and builds up stress. When enough stress has built up, the plate breaks, forming a *fault*. It's like bending a pencil until it cracks -
20 *snap*. The pieces of the broken plate recoil - and quickly slip up, down, or sideways along the fault. This releases the stored energy and sends shock waves in all directions.

These *seismic* waves **rattle** the ground, resulting in earthquakes. Often, stress builds up along the same fault again and again, causing earthquakes to reoccur in the same area. A famous example of this is the San Andreas Fault in California.

25 The spot where rocks begin to move along a fault is called the focus of the earthquake. The focus may be shallow or deep, ranging from close to the Earth's surface to a depth of about 700 km. The point on the Earth's surface directly above the focus is the epicentre. Earthquake tremors are generally strongest near the epicentre.

After a major earthquake, the initial shock waves are often followed by a series of smaller
30 tremors, called aftershocks, which can last for days or weeks. Aftershocks occur when the

Continued...

Earth's crust near the fault "settles" into a new position.

With all that shaking, it's no wonder earthquake tremors can be destructive. In addition to damaging buildings and other structures, earthquakes can also cause tremendous secondary damage from fires, floods, rock slides, mud slides, avalanches *tsunamis* (huge, destructive ocean waves).

Section 3: Where Canucks Feel Quakes

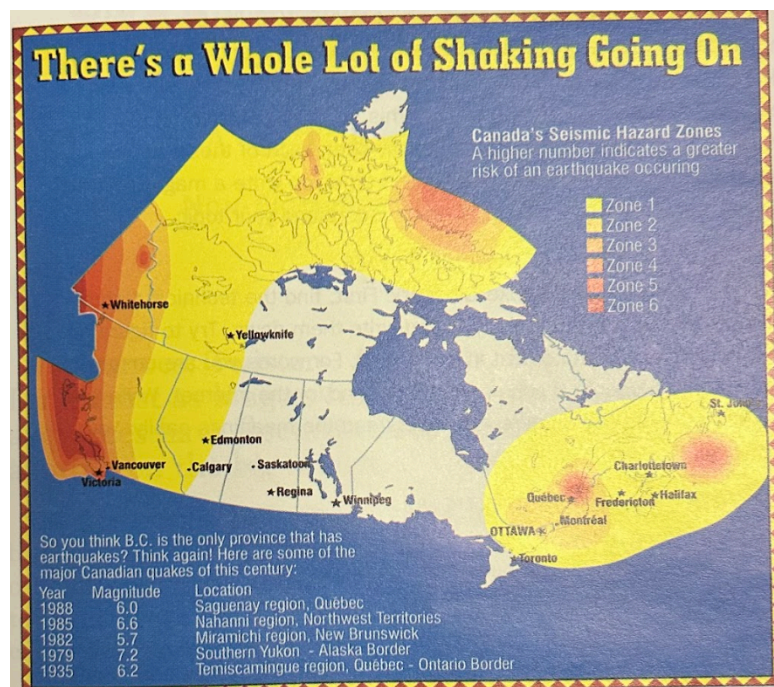
What time is it when everything around you starts shaking and rumbling? It's time for an earthquake. The catch to this riddle is that no one knows exactly when or where an earthquake will occur.

Scientists do know that approximately 97% of the world's earthquakes occur near plate boundaries. Off Canada's west coast three plates interact with each other: the North American plate, the Pacific Plate, and the Juan de Fuca (Wan-da-Foo-ka) Plate. "About 2/3 of Canada's earthquakes are in western Canada or in the western Arctic," reports seismologist Garry Rogers of the Geological Survey of Canada in Sidney, British Columbia. "We locate and catalogue 1000 to 1200 per year in the West."

Nonetheless, notes Rogers, "Earthquakes can affect most of Canada's population." Three percent of the world's earthquakes occur within plates. Most of the earthquakes occurring away from plate boundaries occur along or near ancient fault zones, like the Ottawa valley. These represent zones of weakness where failure is most likely to occur due to *crustal stress*. This helps explain the Ste.-Agathe-des-Monts earthquake that shook people from Ottawa to Montreal on July 30, 1998. It had a magnitude of 4.4 on the *Richter scale*.

Scientists are studying methods of predicting earthquakes, such as measuring stress along faults and observing animals, which act strangely before quakes. As of now, however, there is no reliable way to predict earthquakes.

(End)



X. Read the essay “The Power of Love to Transform and to Heal” and answer questions 64-69 from your Questions Booklet.

The Power of Love to Transform and to Heal

By JACKIE LANTRY

1 I believe in the ingredients of love, the elements from which it is made. I believe in love's humble, practical components and their combined power.

We adopted Luke four years ago. The people from the orphanage dropped him off at our hotel room without even saying goodbye. He was nearly six years old, only 28 pounds and
5 his face was crisscrossed with scars. Clearly, he was terrified. "What are his favorite things?" I yelled. "Noodles," they replied as the elevator door shut.

Luke kicked and screamed. I stood between him and the door to keep him from bolting. His cries were **anguished**, animal-like. He had never seen a mirror and tried to escape by running through one. I wound my arms around him so he could not hit or kick. After an hour and a
10 half he finally fell asleep, exhausted. I called room service. They delivered every noodle dish on the menu. Luke woke up, looked at me and started sobbing again. I handed him chopsticks and pointed at the food. He stopped crying and started to eat. He ate until I was sure he would be sick.

That night we went for a walk. Delighted at the moon, he **pantomimed**.

15 "What is it?" I said, "The moon, it's the moon." He reached up and tried to touch it. He cried again when I tried to give him a bath until I started to play with the water. By the end of his bath the room was soaked and he was giggling. I lotioned him up, powdered him down and clothed him in soft PJs. We read the book One Yellow Lion. He loved looking at the colorful pictures and turning the pages. By the end of the night he was saying, "one yellow lion."

20 The next day we met orphanage officials to do paperwork. Luke was on my lap as they filed into the room. He looked at them and wrapped my arms tightly around his waist. He was a sad, shy boy for a long time after those first days. He cried easily and withdrew at the slightest provocation. He hid food in his pillowcase and foraged in garbage cans. I
25 wondered then if he would ever get over the wounds of neglect that the orphanage had beaten into him.

Continued...

It has been four years. Luke is a smart, funny, happy fourth-grader. He is loaded with charm and is a natural athlete. His teachers say he is well behaved and works very hard. Our neighbor says she has never seen a happier kid.

- 30 When I think back, I am amazed at what transformed this abused, terrified little creature. It was not therapy, counselors or medications. It did not cost money, require connections or great privilege. It was love: just simple, plain, easy to give. Love is primal. It is comprised of compassion, care, security, and a leap of faith. I believe in the power of love to transform. I believe in the power of love to heal.

(End)

XI. Read the following comic and answer questions 70-75 from your Questions Booklet.
Calvin and Hobbes



http://www.rabbittooth.com/13_calvin/spiff/spiff17.jpg